

Printing MONEY!

Inkjets offer excellent print quality at affordable prices. But there is a caveat: the hidden costs of ownership can end up costing you a lot in the long run. We test 22 inkjet printers to find which offers you the right combination of speed, quality and cost per page

The utopia of a paperless office is far from becoming a reality. Ironically, the invasion of computers and digital technology has resulted in just the opposite—more paper than less. And since you cannot avoid printouts—whether it is the quarterly sales reports or that recipe you downloaded from the Net or your child's school project assignment—you might as well give in and get an inexpensive and handy printer that lets you print all those documents without burning a hole in your pocket.

And if you want the option of reasonable quality of output in your colour and black and white prints without having to shell out serious money, then an inkjet printer is the route to go. Once relegated to homes for occasional use, the prices of inkjet printers have been falling over the last few years, even as quality in terms of resolutions (dots per inch) improve. Another improvement is that almost all printers now support a USB interface, which makes printing much faster and installation simpler. Though a laser printer will still give you faster and much better quality prints, the big advantage with inkjets is their low initial cost. You can get a good inkjet printer for as low as Rs 3,000, whereas even the cheapest colour laser printer would cost you nothing less than Rs 30,000.

But there's a catch. While an inkjet printer costs much less initially, and serves as an 'all-rounder' printer capable of printing text and colour images, the operational cost can be quite high. The cost of consumables (ink cartridges and special papers) can add up to quite a bit in the long term.

In this test we've compared some of the best offerings by different vendors across several categories. We've tested them for performance and for cost of operation, so you can pick the most economical printer to serve your needs.

Digit Test Process

Qualification criteria

The printers in this comparison were categorised as:

■ **Budget printers (up to Rs 6,000):** These are entry-level printers that offer reasonable quality but are rather slow while taking colour prints.

■ **Mid-range printers (Rs 6,001 to Rs 12,000):** These are much faster with text and colour printing and have support for higher resolutions.

■ **High-end printers (upwards of Rs 12,000):** These feature ultra fast printing speeds and support for A3 size printing (selective printers).

Our test bed consisted of a Pentium 4 2.2 GHz machine with 256 MB RDRAM and a 20 GB Seagate Barracuda drive. Since the performance of a printer can be affected by the connectivity interface, we configured the parallel port to operate using the ECP+EPP mode (Enhanced Parallel Port/Enhanced Capability Port) which is a standard signalling method for bi-directional parallel communication between a computer and peripheral devices. The USB ports were also enabled on the test bed for printers that featured this interface. We tested each printer on a fresh installation of Windows 2000 Professional to avoid interference with older drivers.

Test methodology

Besides our standard set of parameters such as features (25 per cent weightage), performance (25 per cent), value for money (20 per cent), and warranty (10 per cent), we also tested the printers for total cost of ownership (20 per cent). This is the first time in India that inkjets have been tested for this parameter.

Features: We awarded points depending on the features and capabilities of the printer. These included the printing resolution, maximum paper width supported, connectivity interface to the computer, indicators for